Rajasthan Reimagined for Tourists

In an interview with **India Today**, **DIYA KUMARI**, Deputy Chief Minister, Rajasthan, speaks about diversifying the traveller's experience with festivals, off-beat destinations and year-round events



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Q. Two decades ago, Rajasthan ranked among the top three destinations for tourists, but then the state began to slide in the rankings. What is the situation now?
That slide has stopped. Last year, we had some 230 million tourists, and our biggest achievement has been that our domestic tourists, who began coming to us in big numbers post-COVID, are continuing.

Q. How can you further increase the tourist numbers?
Half of the year is off-season for Rajasthan, but during the season, we have hotels running at full occupancy and we get a lot of international travellers too. But we are working to attract more conferences during the off-season.

Q. Any other initiatives you are planning?
Concert tourism. This can do very well during the off-season. The weather is pleasant in the late evenings, and hotels are cheaper. Fans come from other states as well as districts within Rajasthan for concerts. Then we have some festivals during such months, like Teej and Gangaur, which evoke a lot of interest in other states and countries. We intend to market such festivals.

Q. Rajasthan's major tourist destinations attract a lot of tourists. What about the less-visited ones?
There are many places which have ancient temples, monuments, palaces, havelis and beautiful scenery. Just pick any place like Alwar, Barmer, Dungarpur, Banswara, Bikaner, Bundi, Rajsamand, Kota.... We are looking into ways to market them. Then we have the upcoming Maharana Pratap Circuit that will take tourists through beautiful topography and rich history.

Q. A problem with Rajasthan is that tourists do not extend their stay or make repeat visits. How can you address this?
This is not true. Our wildlife sanctuaries attract tourists again and again. The Jaipur Literature Festival has visitors coming year after year. We only need to have an annual calendar with multiple events so that tourists can plan their visits well.

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Q. Is Shekhawati on the agenda too?
That is a priority. The chief minister held a meeting on how to conserve havelis and other monuments. We are offering incentives to haveli owners to stop them from pulling these down. Our approach is to have a cluster of havelis with restaurants and hotels in or around them. ■

— with Rohit Parihar